



KOREA DEFENSE VETERANS ASSOCIATION

ROK-U.S. ALLIANCE JOURNAL

IN HONOR OF ROK-U.S. COMBINED
FORCES COMMAND

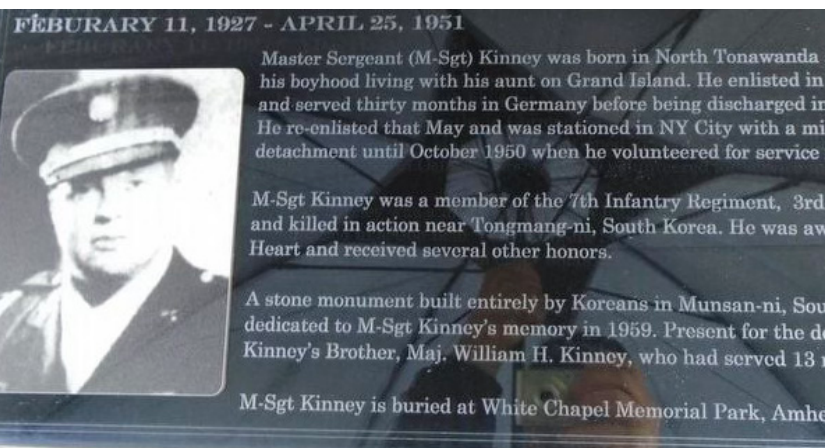
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INTRODUCTION

Dear KDVA Members, Donors, Partners, and Supporters,

As we commemorate the founding of the ROK-U.S. Combined Forces Command (CFC) on November 7, 1978, this issue of the KDVA Journal is dedicated to the men and women who have safeguarded stability on the Korean Peninsula for nearly half a century. The establishment of the CFC marked a historic milestone -- the formal unification of two militaries under one command structure, forged in trust, respect, and shared sacrifice. Since its founding, CFC has stood as a living testament to the strength of the ROK-U.S. Alliance and the commitment to "Fight Tonight" -- together.

Within these pages, you will find stories that reflect the breadth and depth of that Alliance across generations. From recollections of Korean War Veterans returning to a thriving, free Republic of Korea to younger Veterans rediscovering the meaning of service and sacrifice, these reflections remind us that CFC's strength is not only in its military might but in its people. As CSM (Ret.) Diahann White wrote, "The Korea Revisit Program proves that history is not just written in books; it is lived in the memories of those who served." Her words remind us that every Veteran's journey -- from hardship to healing to appreciation -- contributes to the living legacy of our Alliance.

Our Alliance is also carried forward by today's leaders and communities ... from KDVA Chapters in Hawaii, Georgia, Florida, California, Pennsylvania, NYC Metro Area, and Texas, which honor Veterans and share the Alliance story at local events, to the next generation of Americans and Koreans who experience the Alliance not only on the battlefield but through shared endeavors, such as the Seoul Foreign School's races at U.S. Army Garrison Humphreys. SFS Coach Timothy Bazin wrote that these events show how "the ROK-U.S. Alliance is not only defended by soldiers but lived by students -- in sweat, teamwork, and shared pride."

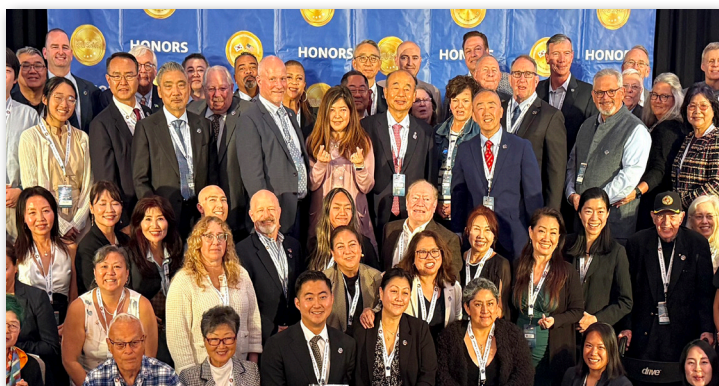
Finally, this issue reminds us that the lessons of the Korean War -- and the creation of the Combined Forces Command -- remain as relevant as ever. As Air Force Col. Andy Bogusky and Dr. John Nagl write, the Korean Peninsula "still balances on the edge of several knives," but deterrence endures because of capable forces, vigilance, and shared will. That enduring vigilance is the very essence of Combined Forces Command.

On this CFC anniversary, we reaffirm our gratitude to all who have served in CFC. Together, we honor a legacy built on partnership, sacrifice, and the unshakable belief that freedom must be defended -- always, and together.

"Together for the ROK-U.S. Alliance!"

General (Ret.) Robert B. "Abe" Abrams
KDVA Chairman and President
Former Commander, United Nations Command
ROK-U.S. Combined Forces Command / U.S. Forces Korea

KDVA MEMBERS



BENEFITS FOR OUR MEMBERS

- Part of a premier professional organization.
- Help strengthen the important ROK-U.S. Alliance ... that you helped build and continue to serve.
- Honor and remember those who have served in Korea.
- Participate in the Korea Revisit Program.
- Participate in KDVA Reunions.
- Networking and access to experts and experiences found nowhere else.
- Mentor and mentee opportunities.
- Staying in touch with those who served with you in Korea.
- Opportunities to participate in forums and events.
- Opportunities to volunteer in leadership positions, internships, scholarships, community service, and be published.

REGULAR MEMBERS:

- Former and current U.S. military & DOD personnel of U.S. Forces Korea ("USFK"), Combined Forces Command ("CFC"), or the U.S. Embassy in Seoul.
- U.S. military & DOD personnel who meet the requirements for the Korea Service Medal ("KSM") or the Korea Defense Service Medal ("KDSM").
- Korean Augmentation to United States Army ("KATUSA") Veterans.
- Retired ROK Military personnel who have served in or been assigned to one of the following for at least three consecutive months.
 - United Nations Command ("UNC").
 - CFC Headquarters and its components.
 - ROK Embassy in the United States.
 - Other ROK-U.S. Combined Commands.
 - MND, JCS, and/or Service HQs.
- Former and current ROK government civilians of CFC and USFK, if ROK law or regulations do not prohibit.

ASSOCIATE MEMBERS:

- U.S. military & DOD personnel who do not meet the requirements for the Korea Service Medal ("KSM") or the Korea Defense Service Medal ("KDSM").
- Adult supporters of the ROK-U.S. Alliance.
- College students who are interested in the U.S.-ROK Alliance.

HONORARY MEMBERS:

- ROK & U.S. distinguished personnel who are dedicated to enhancing ROK-U.S. Alliance.
- Former and current U.S. and ROK government interagency personnel who directly worked or work on ROK-U.S. Alliance topics.

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Revisiting Korea: Honoring Legacy, Inspiring Healing A Unique Lens of Experience

By: CSM (Ret.) Diahann White

As I reflect upon the revisit program, I must first acknowledge the perspective through which I attended. I believe I was one of the youngest veterans in the group, and my service in Korea was among the most recent.

Even though I cannot fully fathom the experience of war in 1950, fought without the technology and resources we rely upon in 2025, I know this much: those men and women broke barriers. They paved the way for veterans and civilians alike to serve integrated within the military. Their contributions must never be overlooked.

A Magnificent Display of Gratitude

The Ministry of Patriots and Veterans Affairs (MPVA) and the Korean Defense Veterans Association (KDVA) coordinated this extraordinary event to ensure that these war heroes could see firsthand the unimaginable impact their service had on a nation once overcome by war.

The mutual gratitude on display was humbling. It was a beautiful reciprocity of respect between the Republic of Korea and those who had answered the call. To see the veterans share this journey with their families was heartwarming. Spouses, children and grandchildren and friends heard stories for the very first time. From a distance, I watched in awe, reflecting on my own tours in Korea, both unaccompanied and accompanied by my spouse.

Healing Through Shared Stories

Listening to the conversations between veterans and their loved ones gave me a deeper appreciation for this often forgotten generation. Yet it was bittersweet to realize that some had suppressed their memories for decades as a coping mechanism. This revisit created space for those stories to surface, and in doing so, allowed healing to begin.

Many veterans shared their most intimate memories, sometimes ones their families had never heard because they were surrounded by comrades who understood. Some had arrived hesitant, even reluctant to return, yet by the end of the week, the program had become a reunion with a past long buried. Friendships were renewed, connections were strengthened, and new bonds were formed.

The Responsibility to Honor

We must seize every opportunity to honor our war heroes while we still can. Their firsthand knowledge is living history full of details and truths that textbooks cannot capture.

The revisit also gave veterans space to confront their return home, which for many was marked by hardship. They had gone to Korea as eager young service members and returned forever changed by the horrors of war. Some were celebrated, but many were condemned or overlooked. For too long, their only memory of Korea was tied to that painful homecoming.

This program allowed them to replace that narrative with one of gratitude, honor, and fulfillment.

Rewriting Narratives: The Story of SSG Martinez

One of the most powerful examples to me was SSG Martinez. His lasting memory of Korea had been of a war-torn nation filled with displaced and impoverished children. But on this trip, his story was rewritten.

He got to witness children being happy, well nourished and just being children. During a choir performance, the children's choir sang ****Jesus Loves Me**** and the children graced the audience and with hugs as they sang. The was spoken about by many of the revisit participants about



how it was so special validating there is no substitute for the human touch!

The following day when we went to Panmunjom. As we were leaving there was a preschool class on a field trip. Mr Martinez asked to stop to see the children (pictured below). He talked and spent a few moments with them. It was an amazing heartwarming moment. It was visible to see Mr. Martinez's heart overflowed with joy.

When called upon to give an impromptu toast at the farewell banquet toast, he shared how the moments of seeing children replaced sorrow with contentment. His transformation validated the importance of the revisit program, not only for honoring veterans but also for giving them the chance to experience healing and joy.

Why the Revisit Program Matters

This is the true power of the Korean War Veterans Revisit Program. It allows veterans to see the lasting impact of their sacrifice: a nation thriving, free, and grateful. It provides them with the highest honor a soldier can receive. The acknowledgment of those whose lives they changed. And it gives them the opportunity to share these experiences with family,

comrades, and future generations who will carry their stories forward.

Looking to the Future

As KDVA continues to expand with new chapters, I hope these opportunities will bring together and connect both war and armistice veterans. By sharing their stories, they can overcome old wounds, preserve a more complete history, and even rewrite difficult narratives into ones that end with honor, hope, and legacy.

The Korea Revisit Program proves that history is not just written in books; it is lived in the memories of those who served. When those memories are shared, acknowledged, and honored, they transform into a legacy that strengthens both nations and generations.

Moments like this aim the enduring value of the Revisit Program. It is not simply a journey back in time, but a pathway to healing, gratitude, and the rewriting of history with dignity and honor.



CELEBRATING KOREAN AND AMERICAN CULTURE THROUGH CROSS COUNTRY: AN EXPERIENCE BY THE SFS CRUSADERS AT U.S. ARMY GARRISON HUMPHREYS



By: Timothy Fuller Bazin, Cross Country Coach and Teacher at Seoul Foreign School

When the Seodaemun-gu based Seoul Foreign School (SFS) Cross Country team arrived at U.S. Army Garrison Humphreys for the Korean-American Interscholastic Activities Conference (KAIAAC) Group C vs. B race, we knew our runners were in for more than just another competition. Of course, every meet affords the opportunity to chase personal records and climb team standings. But trips to HHS Humphreys are also a chance to enjoy a vibrant slice of American culture inside Pyeongtaek, South Korea. With so much focus on the strategic and defensive aspects of the ROK-U.S. Alliance, we often forget the importance of running, eating, laughing, and connecting with others.

Humphreys offers runners one of the flattest courses in South Korea, so every runner has HHS pinned on their calendars. And our team delivered one of its strongest performances of the season:

Boys Varsity XC: While the boys lost 3:1 to Humphreys High School (HHS), they defeated three other strong teams. The race was highlighted by five personal records (PRs), four athletes placing in the top 50 fastest times, and two breaking into the SFS all-time top 10 list - a big accomplishment for a school with nearly 115 years of history.

Girls Varsity XC: The girls team went 4:0 undefeated on the day in an impressive sweep. They also recorded five PRs, placed four runners in the



top 50 fastest, and also celebrated one new entry in the SFS all-time top 10.

Cross country teams are spawning pools for cultures of resilience, hard work, and pride. Much like the soldiers at the Base, our philosophy is “iron sharpens iron.” Sports not only hone the body, they also form some of the strongest bonds between cultures. Cross country, with its long distances and grueling discipline, fosters camaraderie across borders because every runner knows the pain of hills, the strain of strides at the finish, and the satisfaction of giving your personal best.

Yet what happens after the race is sometimes more impactful than what happens during the race. Our students, for instance, were quick to embrace the off-the-course concessions. For some, the highlight was a stop at Popeye’s Chicken, where the taste of Louisiana-style fried chicken overcame the calorie deficits induced by our split times. Others surrendered to Charleys Cheesesteaks where they sampled massive sandwiches that they had only seen on TV or social media. And one coach (yours truly) found that the Base offers “the best fade-style haircuts this side of the East Sea.”

For many SFS athletes, simply being on the Base is a cultural experience unto itself. Humphreys is a place where Korean and American life overlaps. The automobiles and license plates are distinctly American, but the giwa-capped gates and walls are unmistakably Korean. It’s a beautiful *mélange* of Korean and American staff, soldiers, and dependents. At races like these, our students get the rare chance to mix with U.S. military families, converse with base families, and trade stories with the student-athletes who call South Korea a home away from home.

Like the famous ping-pong diplomacy of the 1970s, cross country can be a form of informal diplomacy, where teenage athletes serve as cultural ambassadors united in sweat and the taste of their regurgitated saliva. Perhaps that grosses some readers out, but how else would you describe what happens in a runner’s mouth at the 4k mark?

If you didn’t already know, the Korean-American Interscholastic Activities Conference (KAIAC) was established to bring together international, American, and Korean schools across the peninsula. And KAIAC has long been a model of

inter-cultural exchange in the spirit of the ROK-U.S. Alliance. Every race is both a competition and a cultural event. And, thanks to parents, most events are well supplied with tables selling everything from donuts to tteokbokki.

And then there is the cheering. It’s something that every High School student runs for. And this community cheers for the slowest tortoise just as much as the fastest cheetah.

For our SFS athletes, these experiences are more than extracurricular. They help shape personal identity and worldviews. To eat American food on an American military base, to talk with parents who serve in the U.S. Army, and then to lace up alongside Korean and American peers is to live the Alliance in a deeply personal way.

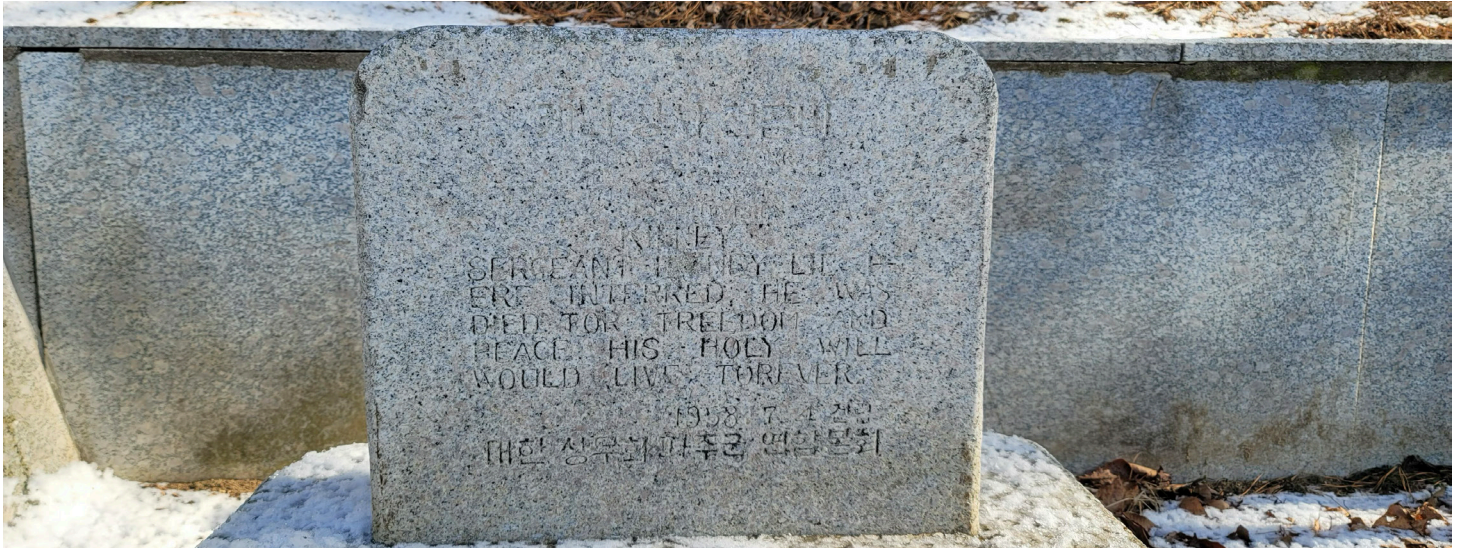
These memories linger longer than race results. Years from now, our athletes may not remember whether they placed 42nd or 47th, but they will remember the pride of representing their school, the thrill of eating Popeye’s after a grueling run, and the camaraderie of the race to the finish.

The ROK-U.S. Alliance is often discussed in terms of security and strategy. But at Humphreys, our students learn its lessons of endurance, discipline, and teamwork. Through intercultural exchange, we nurture the young leaders who understand both the challenges and opportunities of living at the crossroads of Korean and American cultures.

Our experience at Humphreys reminds us why athletics remain a cornerstone of the school experience – and the tremendous role an active and involved Humphreys plays across KAIAC.

In a world where partnerships are tested and diplomacy is often formal, it is refreshing to see teenagers proving, mile after mile, that the ROK-U.S. Alliance is alive and well and growing with every stride.

WALKING THE MEMORY – THE GEORGE H. KINNEY MEMORIAL IN PAJU



By: Minjeong Lee, KIP 2025

The Memorial of Sergeant Kinney (1958)

Along the quiet hillside of Dongmun-ri, Beobwon-eup, in Paju, a small, weathered stone monument stands quietly. At first glance, it seems unremarkable—a simple marker with the name “Sergeant Kinney” engraved on it. Yet, imagining the lives behind such memorials, one can sense the weight of courage and sacrifice carried through the air. This name, so briefly inscribed, belongs to a man whose actions on a distant battlefield left an indelible mark on both American and Korean history.

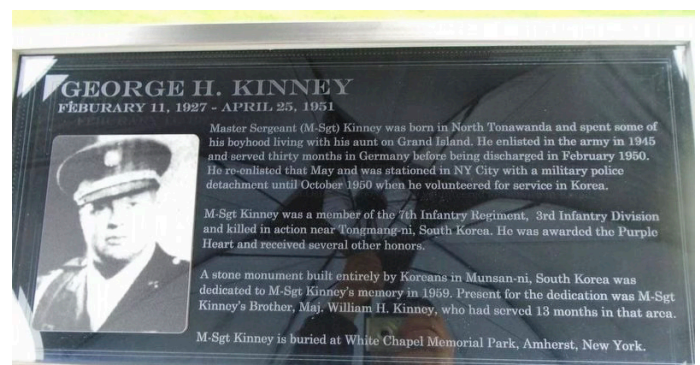
As a child, I often passed by memorials without much thought. Names carved in stone were just names, and the solemnity of their purpose often passed me by. But now, years later, I find myself drawn to such places, compelled to imagine the lives behind the letters, the human stories they conceal. What was the life of “Sergeant Kinney”? Why was he remembered here, on a hillside in Paju, far from his home in North Tonawanda, New York?

The Life and Heroism of George H. Kinney (1927-1951)

George H. Kinney was born on February 11, 1927. He spent part of his boyhood living with his aunt on Grand Island, New York. At eighteen, he enlisted in the U.S. Army, serving thirty months in Germany before being discharged in February 1950. The call of duty, however, led him to re-enlist just three months later. After a brief assignment in New York City with a military police detachment, he volunteered to serve in Korea, joining the 7th Infantry Regiment of the 3rd Infantry Division.

In the spring of 1951, during the Korean War, Kinney's platoon was caught in a sudden North Korean tank attack near Tongmang-ri. Facing near-

certain annihilation, Master Sergeant George H. Kinney, who was serving as the squad leader, along with two of his subordinates, courageously attacked the tanks head-on. Their selfless actions cost them their lives but saved the platoon from destruction, leaving a legacy of extraordinary bravery that continues to be honored in Paju. On April 25, 1951, Kinney died in action during the Korean War. For his courage, he was posthumously awarded the Purple Heart and other honors, yet the greatest tribute remains the memory he left behind—a memory honored thousands of miles away in Paju, where freedom and peace were preserved through his selfless action.



George H. Kinney Marker in Grand Island, Erie County ([https:// www.hmdb.org/m.asp?m=197415](https://www.hmdb.org/m.asp?m=197415))



The Memorial and Its Challenges

The monument in Paju was erected in 1958 by the residents of Munsan-ri in Paju to honor Kinney's heroic act. The dedication was attended by his brother, Major William H. Kinney, who had also served in the region. For decades, this memorial stood as a quiet testament to one man's sacrifice, largely unnoticed by passersby and, for a time, largely unmanaged. Over the years, the monument fell into a state of partial neglect, a stone alone on a hillside, vulnerable to time and weather.

Recently, efforts have been made to revive its presence. The Paju branch of the National Veterans Environmental Movement Headquarters, led by Chairman Yoo Ik-jong have taken voluntary responsibility for its care, conducting small ceremonies and maintaining the grounds. Local authorities and some American military units have occasionally participated in commemorative activities. Yet, these efforts, though meaningful, highlight a larger problem: the memorial's care relies heavily on voluntary contributions, leaving it vulnerable and lacking a consistent, integrated management system.

Adding to the challenge is the monument's inscription, which simply reads "Sergeant Kinney." While it does mention his heroic action, it does not clearly indicate his full name or exact rank, leaving some important details of his identity uncertain for visitors. In recent years, the Paju Veterans Association has taken steps to address this, erecting a new memorial and conducting regular ceremonies to honor Kinney's legacy. These efforts not only preserve his memory but also enrich the site as a space for public reflection, education, and gratitude, transforming what was once a quiet, understated stone into a living testament to courage and sacrifice.



The Memorial of Sergeant Kinney (2019, Paju Veterans Association)

Reflections on Memory and Responsibility

Even in imagination, standing before the Kinney Memorial inspires humility and responsibility. The name etched in stone represents not just a soldier's life but a bridge between two nations and generations.

It reminds us that the freedoms we enjoy were defended by ordinary people placed in extraordinary circumstances. It is easy to pass by, to forget, to leave the story untold. But for those who pause, the monument demands acknowledgment: we are entrusted with memory, tasked to preserve and share it.

This memorial is also a reflection of the broader experience of remembering the Korean War. Across South Korea, countless monuments honor both Korean and foreign soldiers who fought for peace. Some are well-maintained, supported by government funds and community efforts. Others, like the Kinney Memorial, rely on local initiatives and personal dedication, often leaving historical narratives fragmented or partially told. These gaps highlight the importance of coordinated management, accurate historical documentation, and public engagement. By strengthening such efforts, we honor not only the individuals commemorated but also the collective memory and shared values they fought to protect.

For readers, the Kinney Memorial is not just an academic or historical site—it is a space to imagine courage and humanity. History is not only in books or archives but also etched in stone, in memory, and in the hearts of those willing to pause and listen.

In the end, the George H. Kinney Memorial in Paju reminds us that remembering is an active responsibility. It asks us to care, to tell the stories, and to ensure that the sacrifices of the past continue to illuminate the present. Names on stone may fade over time, but the act of remembrance ensures that courage, sacrifice, and friendship endure. Standing quietly before that small monument, one understands something profoundly simple yet essential: some memories demand attention, some stories demand telling, and all of us have a role in keeping them alive.

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KEEPING UP THE COMMITMENT: LINKING MYSELF TO THE ALLIANCE THROUGH RESERVIST TRAINING



By Dae-young Kim, KIP 2025

Last September, I visited my hometown Daejeon – a metropolitan city located in the west-central region of South Korea – to participate in the annual reserve forces training. Since being discharged from mandatory military service in 2021, I've taken part in the once-a-year reservist training starting in 2022. Therefore, this year marks the fourth time that I participated in the training. The training for this year has special significance for me, as it puts an end to my years as a Mobilization Reserve Forces (MRF) personnel, while leading me to a new chapter of life. Through elaborating on my reservist training experience, I'll explain why it is so meaningful to me, as well as show how it connects me to the ROK-U.S. Alliance.

Before getting into the details, I would like to briefly explain the Republic of Korea (ROK) Reserve Forces system. As some people may already know, every adult male ROK citizen over the age of 18 (except those with legitimate cause for exemption, e.g. disability) is required to serve in the compulsory military service for 18 months. After they finish their active service, they are transferred to the reserve forces for another eight years. Thus, they must serve the first four years in the Mobilization Reserve Forces (MRF), and the latter half in the Homeland Reserve Forces (HRF). After those eight years, they are then transferred to civil defense and required to serve there until the age of 40.

I received my reservist training at the site which was formerly known as Camp Ames. It was a former U.S. military base which was located in present-day Jang-dong, Daedeok-gu, Daejeon, South Korea. Since its establishment in 1959, Camp Ames was used as an ammunition depot and tactical nuclear

base by the United States Forces Korea (USFK) for about 30 years. Following the withdrawal of USFK's tactical nuclear weapons, the area was returned to South Korea in 1992. Currently, it is now under the jurisdiction of the Republic of Korea Army (ROKA) Logistics Command, as the ROKA Ammunition Support Command moved here from Haeundae-gu, Busan in 1998.

Now onto my three-day reservist training experience, the first day was nothing special, as it was mostly about welcoming speeches and orientation session. The actual training kicked off the next day, starting with individual firearms training, the most basic part of the entire training. It was then followed by a variety of exercises including Chemical, Biological, Radiological, and Nuclear (CBRN) training, first-aid treatment, and handling injured personnel. As I already practiced such activities during my active service, I had no difficulty in taking part in such trainings, and I actually enjoyed doing them again as a reservist.

After completing basic training, the participants, including myself, were briefed on the missions and tasks we would be performing during wartime. Subsequently, we were divided into groups and received education on each other's assignments, as well as having the chance to practice it until the end of training. Despite some minor differences, most of it was similar to what I carried out during my active service.

Personally speaking, it feels like yesterday that I was discharged from military service, yet four years have already passed since then. As I have finished serving in the MRF, I honestly feel empty inside. Nevertheless, I felt proud to serve my country as a reservist. Through using my expertise and knowledge, I was able to contribute to defending my nation. Thus, I am grateful to my country, the Republic of Korea, for providing me with the opportunity to continue serving and protecting the nation.

Furthermore, this precious experience helped me link myself to the ROK-U.S. Alliance. It is so astonishing that as a reservist, I was assigned to a place which used to be a U.S. army base, since I already served in one during my active service. From January 2020 to June 2021, I served as a ROKA translator in the Combined Forces Command (CFC), which was located in Yongsan-gu, Seoul at the time (now relocated to Camp Humphreys in Pyeongtaek, Gyeonggi Province). There, I was assigned to the Public Affairs Office and was responsible for translating news headlines, press releases, and military documents between English and Korean. In addition, I also took charge of interpreting discussions between the U.S. and ROK officers during briefings and meetings, thus enabling an efficient discussion.



The reservist training that I received greatly reminded me of those memories. Not only was the scenery of the base familiar to me, but the activities I took part in were similar to those that I performed in my years of active service. I feel a sense of being connected to the ROK-U.S. Alliance; whether as an active service-member or a reservist, I am still linked to the Alliance. This realization led me to conclude that I am destined to serve and contribute to the ROK-U.S. Alliance.

Therefore, I decided to keep up the commitment to the Alliance and enter the field of foreign service so that I can keep contributing to preserving and strengthening it. I will continue working hard to achieve my goal of entering the ROK Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MOFA) in the near future. By becoming a diplomat, I aspire to work not only for the Republic of Korea, but also for the better and stronger ROK-U.S. Alliance.

Overall, it was such a memorable experience for me to serve in the MRF and receive its training. By working in the foreign service in the future, I sincerely hope to keep being committed to serving my country as well as contributing to the ROK-U.S. Alliance.

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My Tours in Korea Spanning from 1969 to 1988

By: Brian Mickley



My name is Brian Mickley. I was drafted in the U.S. Army in 1968 and, after basic training and AIT, I went to Infantry OCS at Fort Benning, Georgia and graduated in July 1969. My entire OCS experience prepared me for an assignment to Vietnam. Instead, 30 of my classmates and I got orders to serve in Infantry units in the Republic of Korea. I was assigned as a platoon leader with the 2nd Battalion, 17th Infantry Regiment located at Camp Kaiser, Un Chon Ni, Korea. In those 13 months, I learned a lot about the country and its people and knew that, given the chance, I would return.

After an assignment to Fort Campbell, Kentucky and attendance at my advanced course, I returned to Korea, assigned to Camp Carroll Army Depot in Waegwan, Korea as the Headquarters and Headquarters Company Commander. Of the

400+ soldiers assigned to my unit, around 25% were KATUSA (Korean Augmentation to the US Army) soldiers. I learned a lot about them during my assignment and grew to have a great deal of respect for the way they handled themselves even though they were drafted in the ROK Army.

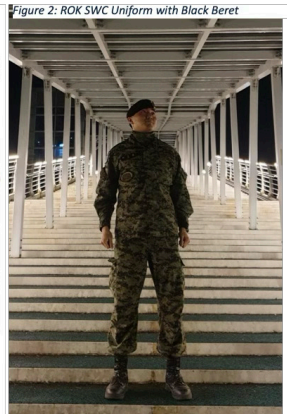
After a three-year assignment in the U.S., I volunteered to return to Korea and was assigned to the 1st Signal Brigade in Seoul, Korea. That assignment gave me the opportunity to see firsthand how Korean and American soldiers worked together to maintain the communications backbone that extended the length of the peninsula.

In 1981, I was assigned as the Deputy Adjutant General of the ROK/US Combined Forces Command in Seoul, Korea. This was a truly unique assignment where members of the ROK and US Army, Navy, Air Force and Marine Corps served together as the headquarters over all military on the peninsula. The headquarters chain-of-command was layered with members of all services and both nations. My immediate supervisor was a ROK Army LTC and his boss was a US Air Force Colonel and his boss was a ROK Navy Commodore. My area was responsible for some traditional personnel functions. Unique to my assignment was the management of a translation unit, as all plans and communications had to be in both languages. We also managed a word processing center that was responsible for the production of bilingual documents. We worked together daily and got to know one another socially as well. That assignment taught me a lot about my fellow ROK officers, and I gained a lot of respect for them and for the daily threat they faced to the north.

After an assignment to the Staff and Faculty at the U.S. Military Academy at West Point, I returned to Korea for my fifth and last tour. I was assigned as the ACSPER (Assistant Chief of Staff for Personnel) of the 19th Area Support Command in Taegu, Korea. We had an active Korean-American Friendship Group and got together socially, played golf and took tours together.

It has now been over 34 years since I retired, and the fondest memories of my 23 years of service were my assignments to Korea. Each taught me a little more about our host nation and their values and commitment to the defense of their homeland. I hope to return one day before I move on from this life to see firsthand what had happened in Korea since I last left just before the Olympics in 1988. I've seen pictures and it looks so much different than the first time I was there in 1969 and the last time I left in 1988.

Special Time, Special Place, Special Occasion



By: Sooyoung Lee, KIP 2025

"Military". This term was never a friendly one to me or my family. None of my family members had served as enlisted soldiers. Some were waived, others transferred to Social Service Personnel, and most served as army surgeons due to their professions.

In South Korea, all men are required to serve in the military for up to 21 months. Despite this obligation, one can choose a specialty, branch, or serve as an officer or NCO. Unlike my family, I wasn't qualified to serve as a surgeon or Social Service personnel, nor did I want to be an officer or NCO. My goal was simple: to serve comfortably, preferably in an office. Being bilingual in Korean and English, I first applied for KATUSA, which allows Korean soldiers to serve with the U.S. Army. I hoped to use my language skills to assist U.S. troops, but I was unlucky and failed the raffle.

I then turned to the English interpreter/translator (TERP) position in the Korean Army, which still allowed me to use my skills in an office environment and work with high-ranking officials. It was a competitive position among Korean men. Fortunately, I advanced to the second round. This was my last chance, as my enlistment date was set for February 15, 2021, at a GOP (General Outpost) base—an isolated, freezing location known for its harsh conditions. Failing the TERP exam would send me there. Motivated by this, I studied intensely, passed the exam, and rescheduled my enlistment to February 22, 2021. I was relieved not only to secure my preferred date but also to increase my chances of serving in an upper division of the Korean Army.

During the 5-week basic training at Nonsan, I prayed to be stationed at either the Combined Forces Command or the Capital Defense Command, both near my home. But my luck ran out. On the training ceremony day, I received my unit assignment: "Special Warfare Command (SWC)." My heart sank. I had heard that all SWC personnel, enlisted or officers, must complete Airborne training. My thoughts repeated: "All that effort to be assigned to

the unit where I wanted to avoid the most." Especially, there were 10 subordinate SWC units, half more than three hours from home. It took me 72 hours to accept my fate.

When I transferred to SWC, my disappointment faded. The headquarters looked like an Avengers Facility. I learned I was assigned to the SWC HQ in Icheon, Gyeonggi Province—only 50 minutes from home. I received new uniforms and specialized gear exclusive to the Korean Special Forces. The black beret, a proud symbol of the ROK SWC, amazed me. Suddenly, I was eager to begin this unexpected chapter.

Serving as an ROK SWC interpreter and translator turned out to be one of the most rewarding experiences of my life. I worked closely with high-ranking officers and learned extensively about special operations of both the Republic of Korea and the United States. I enjoyed studying Korean and English military terminology, exploring how terms related across both languages. My main duty was translating documents between the two languages, depending on the source. Though repetitive, it strengthened my translation accuracy. My comrades and I often practiced mock interpretations to refine our skills.

These efforts paid off during the Combined Command Post Training (CCPT) exercise. While most of my peers stayed at the Combined Special Operations Component Command (CSOCC), I was assigned to the Combined Joint Special Operations Liaison Element (CJSOLE) at Osan Air Force Base, composed of troops from the ROK SWC, the Special Operations Command Korea (SOCKOR), the Air Force Special Operations Command (AFSOC), and the Green Berets from the United States Army Special Operations Command (USASOC). It was my first live interpretation between ROK and U.S. troops. Despite the pressure, I





performed well and earned an appreciation award from the CJSOLE.

Outside the CCPT exercises, many events made my service enjoyable. Yet one stood above all—the airborne training. It was a three-week course that symbolized the essence of the Special Forces. I believed that no matter how much I learned about special operations, I couldn't truly understand them without experiencing one physically. To fully earn the title of a Special Forces translator, I needed to go through the same grueling training the operators endured.

However, the airborne training had strict physical requirements. As an enlisted soldier, it was the only special training I could receive, and eligibility depended on fitness standards. Determined, I worked out daily for three months until I passed the test.

At the Special Warfare School (SWS), I attended an orientation where instructors explained that we must complete four jumps to qualify as paratroopers. But I faced a major obstacle: my extreme fear of heights. I had never enjoyed amusement parks or any activity involving heights. Despite this, I pushed myself to continue. As other Special Forces units such as the ROK Navy's Underwater Demolition Team (UDT), and the ROK Air Forces' Combat Control Team (CCT) come to the SWS regularly for the training, it was physically intense—rolling, crawling, and running nonstop.

One day, I was selected to test my fear by jumping from a mock airborne tower. I froze several times at the edge. Then an instructor whispered, "You will be dismissed unless you jump off the tower right now." The word "dismissed" struck me hard. I jumped. That single moment transformed my fear into courage. Afterward, I faced every drill head-on.

In the final week, we were told we'd make three jumps from a hot air balloon—nicknamed the "White Elephant"—and one from a CN-235 aircraft. The balloon rose 1,000 feet high. Knowing hesitation could become permanent, I jumped each time without pause. The four-second



free fall felt like hours. The hardest part was generating momentum myself, leaping into open air with only my parachute for safety, uncertain if it would deploy. Even then, I couldn't open my eyes or count as required. After three jumps, I felt relieved—until the instructors announced that due to bad weather, the aircraft jump was canceled. We would jump once more from the White Elephant instead.

Climbing the balloon for the fourth time, I felt my fear resurge. Still, I jumped, ignoring procedure entirely. When I landed, the same instructor from before joked, "You've made it, but you will be the last paratrooper with such a severe fear of heights for the next decade."

Three years later, I still remember the thrill of the airborne completion ceremony. My service in the Special Warfare Command, from translation duties to airborne training, became the defining chapter of my life. It proved the truth behind the ROK SWC motto: "Make the impossible, possible."

At the Edge of the Knife: After 75 Years, Korea's Lessons Still Cut Deep

By: **Andy Bogusky and John Nagl**

June 25, 2025, marks the 75th anniversary of the start of the Korean War, a war which technically continues. This date is so impactful that South Koreans refer to this war that continues to divide their homeland as the "6-2-5 War," or simply as the numbers "6-2-5" (pronounced "yook-ee-o"). With over 1.2 million South Korean lives lost—both military and civilian—the Korean War wasn't just a national crisis; it was a deeply personal catastrophe etched into the memory of nearly every household. In the United States, it is often referred to as "The Forgotten War," a tragic misnomer considering over 36,000 Americans lost their lives in just three years. While less than the 58,000 Americans killed in Vietnam over 20 years, the toll reveals the striking intensity and rapid escalation of combat in Korea. But Americans and Koreans were not the only ones to experience loss, as the Korean War also served as the first real test of the United Nations as a military entity, with 14 other countries providing combat units under the United Nations Command, sustaining 3,100 dead.

The losses serve as a grave reminder of a war that offers many lessons. Just two takeaways are offered here: 1) gaps in preparedness invite aggression with the cost of restoring deterrence paid in blood, and 2) the remarkable recovery of the Republic of Korea (South Korea), underwritten by the long-term commitment of the United States, speaks to the continuing relevance of the ROK-U.S. alliance—and other alliances—in today's volatile environment. While deterrence failed in 1950, this robust alliance has prevented the resumption of hostilities on the Korean Peninsula since. Thus, seventy-five years on, the Korean War offers the United States and its allies pertinent lessons about the role of force posture and readiness for achieving deterrence in a world featuring the same players, just at a different time.

The beginning of the Cold War between the United States and the Soviet Union in 1947 set the stage for the first "hot war" in Korea. This war would see communist-aligned North Korea (backed by Russia and China) square off against the United Nations Command-backed South Korea (de facto U.S.-led) along the 38th parallel. Prior to the invasion, the United States transferred the several army divisions that had been in Korea to Japan to oversee occupation and rebuilding efforts there. In the pre-dawn hours of June 25, 1950 North Korean forces, with Russian consent, mounted a surprise attack in which they encountered the reality of the U.S. post-World War II drawdown, which left only U.S. advisors and no combat divisions supporting South Korean forces. It took only three days for the capital of Seoul to fall, and it would take until 1 July for the first U.S. reinforcements to arrive in the form of Task Force Smith.

The next three years would see dramatic shifts in territorial control as the

North Koreans forced the U.S.-led coalition into the southeastern-most city of Busan, then retreated to the Chinese border of the Yalu River, before counter-attacking back to the 38th parallel with Chinese assistance. The Forgotten War illustrates a simple—but not easy—lesson: deterrence requires forward-postured, capable forces and vigilance. Ultimately, deterrence fails when capability and will are in doubt.

Another lesson emerges here, revealing the power and potential of the U.S. alliance framework for mutual prosperity and security—prosperous nations aligned with the United States are not only better equipped to contribute to their own defense, but also to contribute to the collective security of the international system. Not only did the U.S.-led coalition restore the status quo ante bellum in terms of territory, but over time the entire weight of the U.S. instruments of national power were brought to bear, in cooperation with the Republic of Korea, to restore deterrence, establish a vibrant democracy, and transform a war-ravaged nation into the global technology and cultural powerhouse it is today.

An economic comparison between North and South Korea reinforces the compounding effects of partnership with the United States. South Korea, known as "the Miracle on the Han River," evolved from a post-war per capita income of less than \$100, to the world's 13th largest economy. On the other hand, North Korea, despite sharing ethnic homogeneity and basic geographic position, ranks 89th. Not only is South Korea thriving economically, but it contributes globally to deterrence, security, and peace—unlike its northern neighbor, which is widely regarded as a destabilizing global pariah. South Korea provides over \$1 billion annually to host 28,500 U.S. servicemembers and crossed \$14 billion of annual defense exports to 12 countries in 2023. The Republic of Korea has been a reliable security exporter and global partner by contributing coalition forces to Vietnam, Afghanistan, Iraq, anti-piracy operations, and peacekeeping operations. The takeaway is clear: alliances rooted in shared values and sustained through mutual investment are not only strategic assets and in the interests of the United States, they are also engines of transformation that multiply power, boost deterrence, and shape a more stable global order.

But South Korea still balances on the edge of several knives. While the ROK-U.S. alliance enforces an armistice that secures a fragile peace in a war that has not officially ended, skirmishes continue along the 155-mile blade designated as the demilitarized zone (DMZ). Occasional provocations by a nuclear-armed North Korea threaten to slice open the seams of conflict; as of this writing, North Korea conducted at least five missile launch events in 2025, including an alleged new hypersonic missile. Not only is deterrence and security of South Korea important to the Korean Peninsula, but it also represents an island of stability in a troubled region, where South Korea



sits on a broader strategic knife-edge. The strategic geography of the Korean peninsula makes it a fulcrum in the Indo-Pacific—bordering China, Russia, and Japan. The commitment of military personnel in Korea not only deters North Korean aggression and its nuclear ambitions, but also serves as a regional hedge against China and Russia, especially with the Republic of Korea's role in regional security frameworks such as U.S.-ROK-Japan trilateral cooperation.

Therefore, as policymakers and military leaders reflect on the start of the Korean War 75 years ago—a fiery eruption that receded into a perpetual simmer—we can draw parallels to current events and ask questions about future scenarios. In his memoirs, President Harry Truman stated the decision to help South Korea was intended to prevent its collapse, which would, in turn, encourage “China and the Soviet Union to attack other nations, resulting in World War III.” The same logic applies today with the Russia-Ukraine war and a potential China-Taiwan conflict. The U.S. military has attempted to pivot to the Pacific for over a decade. However, many Americans still grapple with the reality of China's rhetoric, preparation, and exercises to invade its democratic neighbor, Taiwan. Certainly, parallels can be drawn between the Korean War and Russia's invasion of Ukraine, but we should view Russia's ambitions in broader terms. Some agree with the opinion of Hamish de Bretton-Gordon, a retired British Army officer, that Russian President Vladimir Putin's invasion of Ukraine “brought the Cold War back to Europe, which could at any time turn hot.” Other experts, such as former deputy national security advisor Elliott Abrams, take a broader perspective, arguing that a “new Cold War” has been “brought upon the West by the aggressive partnership of Xi Jinping and Vladimir Putin.” Yet others imply we are potentially in the opening phases of World War III. If this is the case, then we may be where we started prior to the Korean War, and would be wise to consider This Kind of War, where T.R. Fehrenbach surmises,

Because the American people have traditionally taken a warlike, but not military, attitude to battle, and because they have always coupled a certain belligerence—no American likes being pushed around—with a complete unwillingness to prepare for combat, the Korean War was difficult, perhaps the most difficult in their history.

These words by Fehrenbach cut like a knife, one that remains sharp if we were to use them to examine America's current preparedness for war. Is the United States postured with the right forces in the right places? Are decision-makers and military leaders vigilant and clear-eyed on the prospects for conflict with Russia and China? And finally, is the American public ready to stomach the costs of war if it is necessary?

While not the case on June 25, 1950, the U.S.-ROK alliance today serves as an excellent example of deterrence through forward posture, capable forces, and vigilance. The United States should strengthen this and other key alliances to promote economic strength, political stability, and technological advancement, which enables U.S. allies to build capable, professional militaries; invest in interoperable defense systems; and participate meaningfully in joint operations and peacekeeping. The U.S. alliance system thus becomes more than the sum of its individual parts—instead it evolves into a tightly woven mesh of burden-sharing states that reinforce regional stability, respond to crises, and reinforce the rules-based international order. In the end America and its allies can reinforce the shield of deterrence with forward postured, capable forces, possessing the will and capability to defend our interests and prove the lessons of the Korean War are not forgotten.

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STANDING TOGETHER: REFLECTIONS ON THE ROK-U.S. COMBINED FORCES COMMAND



By Sicily Giamanco, KIP 2025

On November 7, 1978, the Republic of Korea and the United States established the Combined Forces Command, known simply as CFC. This new command marked a turning point in the Alliance. It was not just a restructuring of military leadership but a clear decision to operate as one unified team, reflecting trust and shared responsibility between two nations committed to the security of the Korean Peninsula. The creation of CFC was the culmination of years of dialogue and planning, and it represented a strategic choice to institutionalize a level of military integration unprecedented between the two countries.

The late 1970s were uncertain years. The United States had recently withdrawn from Vietnam, leaving questions about its commitment to alliances in Asia. At the same time, North Korea's military expansion continued at an alarming speed, with growing investments in artillery, armored divisions, and missile technologies. The axe murder incident of 1976 at Panmunjom, in which two U.S. Army officers were killed during a tree-trimming operation in the Demilitarized Zone, served as a stark reminder of the precariousness of peace on the peninsula. This incident shocked the international community and prompted urgent discussions in both Seoul and Washington about the need to strengthen military cooperation. In response, the Allies concluded that they needed more than coordination. They needed a unified command structure capable of deterring aggression and, if necessary, conducting rapid, coordinated military operations that could respond to any threat with precision and speed.

CFC's structure was unique and forward-looking. A U.S. four-star general would serve as Commander, while a ROK four-star general would serve as Deputy Commander. Staff positions were shared between the two nations to ensure both had a voice in planning, operations, and decision-making. This arrangement was more than symbolic. It established mechanisms for trust, accountability, and joint responsibility. Soldiers, sailors, airmen, and marines learned to work side by side, overcoming differences in training, doctrine, and language. The daily collaboration built bonds that strengthened both military effectiveness and diplomatic confidence between the two governments. Officers and enlisted personnel participated in regular exchange programs to understand each other's procedures and culture, which created a foundation for seamless cooperation during operations and exercises.

Over the decades, CFC has been tested repeatedly. Combined exercises such as Team Spirit in the 1980s, Key Resolve in the 1990s and 2000s, and Ulchi Freedom Shield in recent years developed a deep level of interoperability. Veterans recall the challenges of working across different military cultures and languages. Coordinating logistics, standardizing communication procedures, and synchronizing operations often required patience and innovation. Yet participants also remember the pride of achieving objectives together. In one exercise, participants practiced combined amphibious landings and air defense drills under simulated attack conditions. The coordination required multiple branches from both nations to operate seamlessly, demonstrating the true value of combined planning. These exercises also included civilian coordination, such as emergency medical services and infrastructure security, showing that CFC's operational readiness extended beyond purely military scenarios.

The command evolved in response to changing circumstances. In 1994, South Korea regained peacetime operational control of its forces, reflecting both the maturity of its military and U.S. confidence in the Republic's capabilities. Since then, discussions about the transfer of wartime operational control have continued. The vision of a future CFC led by a Korean commander, supported by American forces, reflects mutual respect and the evolution of a more equal and capable security partnership. This transition highlights the adaptability of the Alliance rather than weakening it. Analysts note that such a shift demonstrates strategic foresight, preparing South Korea for independent command while retaining the deterrent effect of U.S. support.



Relocation of the headquarters from Yongsan in Seoul to Camp Humphreys in Pyeongtaek, completed in 2022, represents another milestone. Camp Humphreys is now the largest overseas U.S. military base in the world, equipped with modern facilities and integrated infrastructure to support joint operations. The move was not simply logistical. It symbolized modernization of the Alliance and a commitment to readiness in a rapidly changing security environment. The base's expanded airfields, training areas, and communication systems allow the Allies to respond quickly to regional contingencies. The relocation also consolidated scattered units and improved the living conditions for service members and their families, reflecting a long-term investment in morale and operational effectiveness.

Today, CFC operates in an increasingly complex security environment. North Korea's advancing nuclear and missile programs dominate headlines, but threats extend beyond conventional warfare. Cybersecurity challenges, chemical and biological weapons, and rapid technological change demand constant adaptation. The command has expanded its mission to include counter-chemical, biological, radiological, and nuclear planning, cyber defense operations, and integration of new technologies, including unmanned aerial systems and enhanced intelligence-sharing platforms. Each adaptation demonstrates CFC's capacity to evolve without compromising its core mission: the defense of South Korea and the preservation of peace. Analysts emphasize that this evolution reflects broader trends in military strategy, where technological innovation and joint planning are essential for effective deterrence.

CFC is defined not only by strategy and operations but by the people who make it work. Daily life at the command involves Koreans and Americans working side by side. They share duties, learn from each other, and celebrate cultural events together. Soldiers exchange not only tactical expertise but personal experiences, building trust that transcends rank and nationality. One example is the annual combined holiday celebration, where units prepare meals together, perform cultural demonstrations, and host joint ceremonies to recognize service and achievement. These experiences reinforce the human dimension of CFC and make the concept of a combined force tangible. Small, everyday interactions, such as joint training in language skills or participating in community outreach programs, further strengthen bonds between personnel and their families.

The command also contributes to broader regional stability. By demonstrating a credible and united deterrent, CFC helps reduce the risk of miscalculation by adversaries. Exercises and readiness activities serve not only defensive purposes but also signaling functions, reinforcing U.S. commitment to South Korea and sending a clear message about Alliance strength to the wider region. For instance, the large-scale Key Resolve exercises in the early 2000s simulated rapid deployment and high-intensity combat operations, showing North Korea and other observers that combined forces could act decisively under pressure. These exercises strengthened deterrence and built

confidence among Allies. Additionally, CFC's integrated intelligence operations provide early warning capabilities that enhance both strategic planning and crisis management.

The legacy of CFC extends to all who have served within it. Veterans recall the challenges of building a shared operational culture, long hours spent planning and training, and the satisfaction of seeing cooperation in action. From administrative staff to combat-ready units, every member contributes to the effectiveness of the command. Their collective experience reinforces the notion that security is maintained not only through strategy and technology but through relationships, shared values, and the willingness to act together in defense of common principles. Many former personnel speak of lifelong friendships and professional networks forged through their service, which continue to strengthen bilateral ties long after they leave active duty.

As CFC approaches its fiftieth anniversary, its significance remains clear. It has preserved peace on the Korean Peninsula for nearly half a century, combining military strength with trust, collaboration, and adaptability. The decision made on November 7, 1978, was not simply bureaucratic. It was a deliberate choice to institutionalize a partnership capable of meeting both present and future challenges. The command's continued evolution reflects the dynamic nature of international security and the enduring importance of alliances in maintaining stability. In an era of global uncertainty, CFC serves as a model for how multinational military cooperation can maintain peace and promote regional security.

In conclusion, the ROK-U.S. Combined Forces Command stands as a testament to what can be achieved when nations commit to shared security and collective responsibility. Its history is a story of adaptation, cooperation, and trust, demonstrating that peace is maintained not by chance but through sustained commitment, foresight, and collaboration. As we reflect on five decades of combined operations, the lesson is clear: security is strongest when it is shared, and partnerships built on trust endure far beyond any individual crisis or challenge. The story of CFC reminds us that enduring peace is the product of constant effort, careful planning, and the belief that two nations can accomplish more together than alone. This enduring legacy underscores the value of international alliances in preserving stability and provides lessons for future generations of military leaders and policymakers.

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Semi-Sesquicentennials of 2025: Marking Milestones for the US-ROK Alliance Part 1



Korean War veterans stand during the commemoration ceremony in Suwon.

By: Andrew Kim, KIP 2025

This year of 2025 marked several important semi-sesquicentennials for the US-ROK Alliance. Whereas 75th anniversary commemorations in 2020 celebrating Allied victory in the Second World War (i.e., V-E Day and V-J Day) as well as nearly contemporaneous celebrations of Korean liberation (Gwangbokjeol) which resulted from the Allied triumph were muted and suppressed by COVID contagion, the semi-sesquicentennials of 2025 were marked with appropriately open and widespread ceremony. This year marked the 75th anniversary of the outbreak of the Korean War, the formation of the United Nations Command via UN Security Council Resolution 84, the successful defense of the Pusan Perimeter, and the decisive Operation Chromite (Incheon Landing) which turned the tide of the war. I had the honor

of being invited to attend several of these milestone ceremonies held in Korea.

First, I was invited to attend the 75th anniversary commemoration of “Yug-i-o” (i.e., the outbreak of the Korean War on June 25th, 1950) hosted by Gyeonggi Province at the Gyeonggi Business and Science Accelerator building in Suwon. The ceremony hall was filled with dignitaries from the provincial government, distinguished guests from the armed forces and veterans’ organizations, and most significantly approximately 30–40 Korean War veterans. The ceremony followed a meticulous schedule with the upmost respect for the occasion, featuring such events as the presentation of the flags of UN member states that participated in the war, speeches by various dignitaries, and music provided by the military band of the ROK Marine Corps Headquarters and a group of schoolgirls.



Interviewing the head of the Korean War Veterans Association's Gyeonggi Branch, Kim Hong-soo.

By far the highlight of the event was provided by Kim Hong-soo, Korean War veteran and head of the Gyeonggi Branch of the Korean War Veterans Association, who forcefully delivered a twenty-minute recorded speech on the history of the Korean War. After the ceremony, I was invited to the Korean War Veterans Association's Gyeonggi Branch office to record video interviews with Kim and three other Korean War veterans.

The veterans all had a vigor and a clearness of mind that was striking even in our current age of advanced medical care and longevity. If retirement once meant a withdrawal from work and larger society, these veterans, now in their 90s, do not "retire" from society as much as they "re-tire" before racing towards the next pit stop of life. Gyeonggi Branch head Kim Hong-soo was born on July 9th, 1931 in modern-day Seogwipo in southern Jeju Island. Being a native of the island during this period meant that, unlike most Koreans, Kim bore witness to not one but two epochal tragedies in the wake of Korea's post-WWII liberation: the Jeju 4-3 Incident and the Korean War. He told me how his elder sister and her entire family, including young children, were massacred by insurgents during the Jeju 4-3 Incident. A product of this Cold War crucible, Kim passionately served his country in the defense of the Pusan Perimeter, fighting in the Angang area during the Battle of Gyeongju and the defense of Pohang.

Kim ended up serving in various other battlefields throughout the war, with Kim personally relating several harrowing episodes from these battles to me. Having been assigned to an observation post on Hill 949 (north of Baekamsan Mountain) as a forward observer, Kim, then a second lieutenant

serving in the ROK 3rd division, was reporting the result of a successful mortar strike on the opposing Chinese positions on Hill 662 when an explosion rocked the post he was in. Checking his surroundings, he soon realized that his sunbae, Second Lieutenant Lim, who was standing outside the entrance of the post to observe the enemy positions was directly hit by an enemy artillery round and was instantly disintegrated. Kim and his men were only able to salvage scattered bits of clothing, scattered remains of money (given to Lim in anticipation of his imminent marriage leave), and part of Lim's left arm.

Another episode came from his earlier participation in the Battle of Seoraksan Mountain, in which Kim was tasked with leading two squads of men in ambushing and capturing a group of looting North Korean soldiers who were spending the night in an isolated house on a mountain ridge. After unexpected gunshot noise woke the North Koreans in the house, the ROK troops were forced to wipe out the enemy before they could escape, but Kim and his men were nearly wiped out themselves as KPA troops soon emerged with daybreak. Kim remembered leading his men into a ravine for cover from withering enemy fire. Miraculously, all participating ROK troops survived the encounter. My full interview with Kim, along with my many other interviews with Korean War veterans are available for viewing on my YouTube channel "Voices of the Forgotten War."

September 15, 2025 marked the 75th anniversary of the Incheon Landing, with September 15th, 1950 constituting the date of the amphibious landing phase of the Battle of Incheon. The semi-sesquicentennial was celebrated on a grand scale, with numerous events on various themes including the Battle of Incheon, Incheon as a "international city of peace," and Korean reunification taking place over the course of a week across the city of Incheon. Specifically pertaining to the Battle of Incheon, relevant events included a commemoration ceremony for the war dead of the ROK Naval Intelligence Unit, which carried out crucial intelligence operations on Yeongheung Island prior to the landings (events portrayed in the Korean movie "Operation Chromite"), a wreath-laying ceremony at the Douglas MacArthur statue at Freedom Park, and another wreath-laying ceremony for the civilian victims of the Wolmi Island bombardment which preceded the landings on Green, Red, and Blue Beaches on September 15th.

During this time, I was accompanying members of the KDVA leadership, including KDVA President, fmr. USFK, CFC, and UNC Commander Robert Abrams, fmr. US 8th Army Commander Michael Bills, and fmr. Seventh Air Force Commander Thomas Bergeson, during their one-week schedule in Korea with KUSAF leadership. During that week, we had arranged meetings with the ROK Minister of Patriots and Veterans Affairs, the ROK Minister of Defense, the Korea Chamber of Commerce and Industry, the National Intelligence Service, the acting US Chargé d'Affaires ad interim in Korea, and various business, church, and army leaders associated with KDVA. We also visited Pyeongtaek, where KDVA leadership met with current USFK, CFC, and UNC Commander Xavier Brunson and the leadership of the prospective KDVA Humphreys Chapter and where we attended the 2025 Pyeongtaek International Peace Forum. The headline event of the week was the KDVA-KUSAF US-ROK Alliance and Veterans Conference and Gala held at the Westin Josun Seoul, which was attended by three



USFK commanders (Abrams, LaCamera, and Brunson), fmr. USFK servicemembers, and numerous other distinguished guests. Prior to this, we also attended the aforementioned 75th anniversary celebrations in Incheon, first joining the unveiling ceremony for a new monument dedicated to the Incheon landings at Wolmi Park near the site of the initial landing at “Green Beach.”



Meeting USFK, CFC, and UNC Commander Xavier Brunson at the US-ROK Alliance Veterans Conference and Gala.



KDVA leadership, including General Abrams, Lt. Gen. Bergeson and Lt. Gen. Bills, at Camp Humphreys.

The highlight of the Incheon semi-sesquicentennial was the commemoration ceremony of the September 15 landings, which took place at Pier 8 of the Incheon Inner Port, near the site of the “Red Beach” landing and at the site of a major tourism and infrastructure redevelopment project for the city of Incheon. Throngs of people totaling over 1,500 people were present, including Korean War and Incheon Landing veterans and representatives from 22 nations which

participated in the war, Commander Brunson and the ROK military's high brass, and the mayor of Incheon. The highlight of the event was an enactment of the landings in which assets of the current ROK navy including the AW-159, UH-60, and MUH-1 helicopters, “KAAV” amphibious assault vehicles, and “LCM” landing craft. Several warships were deployed in the harbor for the event, including the ROKS Gang Gam-chan, the deck of which served as the venue for a celebratory dinner for VIP guests including KDVA leadership. Although critiques of MacArthur and even of some actions within the Incheon landings (specifically the bombardment of Wolmi Island) are extant in Korean society (we passed by some protestors demanding a civilian return to an area of the island now occupied by Wolmi Park), the occasion was marked by positive reviews and reception from Korean media and the general public, showcasing the wider societal consensus that the battle constituted a “back from the brink” moment for the ROK.

Continued in Part II -

An unveiling ceremony for a new monument at Wolmi Park dedicated to the Incheon Landing.

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KDVA HAWAII CHAPTER UPDATE

By: Chapter President, Rich Lencz

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and moments of reflection, the gathering underscored the enduring gratitude felt by Veterans and all Hawaiians for the bravery and service of these veterans.

The following day, on June 26th, KDVA Hawaii hosted a warm and celebratory Meet & Greet, placing Korean War Veterans at the center as guests of honor. The event fostered camaraderie and connection, allowing attendees to engage directly with the veterans, hear their stories, and express appreciation in a more personal setting. It served as a meaningful continuation of the commemorative efforts, blending remembrance with fellowship and reinforcing the bonds between generations and communities.

In addition, on October 19th, KDVA Hawaii volunteers assisted in cleaning up the Hawaii Korean War and Vietnam War Memorials located at the state capital. The KDVA Hawaii Chapter looks forward to hosting another meet & greet in November to honor our Korean Defense Veterans.

On June 25, 2025, the KDVA Hawaii Chapter paid tribute to Korean War Veterans during the 75th Commemoration of the Korean War Ceremony held at the National Memorial Cemetery of the Pacific. The solemn event brought together veterans, families, and community members to honor the sacrifices and legacy of those who served during the Korean War. With ceremonial wreaths, heartfelt speeches,



KDVA GEORGIA CHAPTER UPDATE

By: Chapter President, Kevin Miller

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The KDVA Georgia Chapter conducted our summer Meet & Greet on 20 June 2025 inside the National Infantry Museum at Fort Benning, near Columbus, GA. During this joint event, we announced a partnership between KDVA and the National Infantry Museum and expressed a desire to work together in support of our important mission. ROK Army Officers attending the Maneuver Captain's Career Course and many KDVA members from around the region attended this wonderful event. Major General Colin Tuley, Commanding

General of the Maneuver Center of Excellence and Fort Benning, provided remarks on the importance of the ROK-U.S. Alliance and his pride in having served in the Republic of Korea. Brigadier General (Retired) Peter Jones, President of the National Infantry Museum Foundation and a veteran of the Joint Security Area, spoke of his service on peninsula and his pride in being a member of KDVA.

In July, KDVA participated in the American Korean Friendship Society's Korean War Armistice Day Commemoration and Wreath Laying Ceremony. KDVA Georgia Chapter President Kevin L. Miller represented KDVA while attending two ROK-U.S. Alliance panel events for the Atlanta Council on International Relations and the World Affairs Council of Atlanta.

The Korean American community in Atlanta hosted two festivals in honor of the Chuseok holiday, and KDVA members were honored to attend. Both were great community events that showcased Korean culture, music, and food.

Additionally, KDVA GA leadership was honored to attend the Korean National Day celebration hosted by the Republic of Korea Consulate in Atlanta. The annual event provided a great opportunity to recognize the accomplishments of the Republic of Korea and to further strengthen the ROK-U.S. Alliance through community engagement.



KDVA FLORIDA CHAPTER UPDATE

By: Chapter President, Larry Tressler

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Mid-year, the Florida Chapter of KDVA was represented recently at the 75th anniversary of the Korean War commemoration ceremony in Tampa, hosted by the Korean American Association of West Florida. Guest speakers with commemorative remarks included Jane Castor - Mayor of Tampa, Col. Hyungdo Kwan - Republic of Korea Liaison to U.S. Central Command, and KDVA's Florida Chapter President, Larry Tressler. Just a few days prior, KDVA Florida Chapter held a "Meet & Greet" honoring Korea Veterans at the Yuengling Brew Haus in Tampa. Guest speaker Lt. Gen. (Ret.) Michael Bills (KDVA Vice Chairman and former Eighth Army Commander in Korea) talked about KDVA and Korea, concluding with a Q & A session with the group. Each veteran went home with a Korea challenge coin in addition to souvenirs of the event.

In August, KDVA was represented and promoted at the National Liberation Day & Korea / U.S. Alliance celebration in Orlando sponsored by the Central Florida Korean Association. About 150 people attended this event.

In October, KDVA representation returned to Orlando to share a Korean Thanksgiving celebration with the CFKA. Entertainment was provided followed by a large Korean meal.

Also in October, the KDVA Florida Chapter was represented on an Honor Flight to Washington D.C. At a stop at the Korean War Veterans Memorial, Chapter President Tressler had the honor to speak with many Korea veterans who shared their stories.

In the months to come, the Florida Chapter of KDVA plans to attend multiple community events and host additional "Meet & Greet" across the state.



KDVA CALIFORNIA CHAPTER UPDATE



By Chapter President, Hank Kim

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KDVA California Chapter was inaugurated in December of 2024 and is being led by our President, Captain Hank Kim, an Active Duty Navy Officer. The chapter has been growing steadily through quarterly "Meet & Greet" (M&G) socials and community engagements. CA Chapter's latest M&G in May was a huge hit and enticed many Active Duty Navy personnel from nearby bases to join! Captain Kim recently represented KDVA at a San Diego based non-profit organization called House of Korea (HoK). HoK promotes Korean culture for local San Diegians culminating in an annual gala. KDVA proudly sponsored a table and CA Chapter members introduced our organization to many local community leaders.

Additionally, in August, KDVA CA was invited as an award presenter for another non-profit organization called Korea Freedom Federation (KFF) based in Los Angeles. KFF hosted a video essay

contest for local high school students to showcase the value of the US-ROK Alliance; this laudable goal was in alignment with KDVA's objectives! CAPT Kim proudly presented 3 awards and spent a few minutes speaking to the audience about KDVA, continuing to expand our reach in the Golden State.

The highlight of the year thus far was the 2025 KDVA Reunion held for the first time in San Diego this October. With over 150 personnel from all over the US as well as South Korea in attendance, KDVA members celebrated the Republic of Korea and US Alliance, shared memories of the Korean War, and discussed important topics impacting the Korean Peninsula and surrounding region. We were honored to have the new KDVA Chairman & President, Gen. (Ret.) Robert "Abe" Abrams; the former Chairman of the ROK Joint Chiefs of Staff, Gen. (Ret.) Jung Seung-Jo; and former U.S. Deputy Chief of Mission in Seoul, Mr. Mark Tokola, among the many honored guests at our conference.



KDVA PENNSYLVANIA CHAPTER UPDATE



By Chapter President, Andy Bogusky

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The KDVA PA Chapter was recently launched this year on 9 May 2025 in Carlisle, PA. The roughly 70 attendees included students and faculty of the US Army War College located at Carlisle Barracks, two Korean War Veterans and members of their families, and the ROK Army student and his family. Welcome remarks were provided by then KDVA Chairman & President, Gen. (Ret.) Curtis Scaparrotti, and KDVA Senior Vice President of Operations, Col. (Ret.) Steve Lee. The PA Chapter is helmed by Air Force Colonel Andy Bogusky, who serves as a faculty instructor at the Army War College.

As Pennsylvania hosts several military installations and has a large veteran population, the KDVA PA Chapter looks forward to hosting future events that will engage and support KDVA members with fellowship and networking opportunities. Carlisle serves as a unique "hub" due to the annual rotation of 300+ students who attend the Army War College, many of whom have served in Korea, but the PA Chapter also plans to expand events to other cities like Pittsburgh and Philadelphia. If you live in one of these areas and would like to attend a KDVA event please contact the PA Chapter president, Andy, at abogusky.kdva.pa@gmail.com.

KDVA NEW YORK CITY CHAPTER



By: Chapter President, BG (Ret.) Chris Stockel
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On June 6, 2025, KDVA launched the New York City Metro Area Chapter at The Korea Society in New York City. KDVA Chairman & President, Gen. (Ret.) Abe Abrams, provided opening remarks and introduced the new KDVA NYC Chapter President, Brig. Gen. (Ret.) Chris Stockel. After brief comments, the attendees enjoyed locally prepared Korean food. Participants were a mix of KDVA members and Korea Society enthusiasts. We were honored that Korean War Marine Veteran, Mr. Jack Foley, attended.

On July 25th, the KDVA NYC Chapter and The Korea Society collaborated in presenting "Remembering the Korean War." The event highlighted the Armistice Agreement signed on July 27, 1953. Korean War Veteran Jack Foley and KDVA NYC Chapter President Stockel were the featured speakers.

The chapter intends to do its next "Meet and Greet" in mid-December.



KDVA TEXAS CHAPTER UPDATE



By Chapter President, BG (Ret.) Gene Meredith
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Howdy from the great state of Texas KDVA Chapter. We initiated our chapter on 5 SEP with our launch Meet & Greet at the San Antonio VFW Post 76. We were honored to have LTC (Ret.) Mike Bills (KDVA Vice Chairman and former Eighth Army Commander) as our guest speaker, bringing us up to date on the U.S.-ROK Alliance. We were also pleased to see LTC (Ret.) John Evans (former Deputy Commanding General -Support for 2nd Infantry Division) as well as two Korean War Veterans. In total, we had 75 attend the gathering.

Following the Kick Off Gathering, CSM (Ret.) David Carr and I attended the Randolph AFB Retirement Day on 13 September where we were able to contact over 100 Veterans and possible KDVA Members. Unfortunately, the Brook Army Medical Center Retirement Day was postponed due to the government shut down but we look forward to participating when it is rescheduled.

We are looking forward to our next Meet and Greet in the Fort Hood/Killeen area in the New Year. We will get the details out as soon as we have them.



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